

Three biologically based characteristics contribute to an individual's vulnerability. First, people prone to emotion dysregulation react immediately and at low thresholds (high sensitivity). Second, they experience and express emotion intensely (high reactivity), and this high arousal dysregulates cognitive processes too. Third, they experience a long-lasting arousal (slow return to baseline).

This biological vulnerability is exacerbated, and in some cases even created, by transactions between the emotionally vulnerable person and a social environment that is pervasively invalidating. Some forms of Trauma can be seen as emotional invalidation.

The Core Idea: Emotion Dysregulation

DBT starts from the premise that many psychological problems—especially severe ones—stem from an inability to manage emotions effectively. When someone can't regulate their emotions naturally, they may develop extreme behaviors either as a direct result of being emotionally overwhelmed or as desperate attempts to get their emotions back under control.

The term "biosocial" suggests this happens through an interaction between biological factors (like a person's inborn emotional sensitivity) and social factors (particularly their environment growing up).

Three Key Propositions:

1. **Dysfunctional behaviors are about emotion regulation** - Things that look like "bad behavior" or psychiatric symptoms are often the person's way of trying to manage overwhelming emotions or are direct consequences of losing emotional control.
2. **Invalidation compounds/maintains the problem** - When a person's emotional experiences are dismissed, minimized, or contradicted by others ("you're overreacting," "it's not that bad"), this prevents them from learning healthy emotion regulation. The invalidation compounds and keeps the dysregulation going.
3. **Secondary problems emerge** - As someone struggles with both emotion dysregulation and ongoing invalidation, they develop patterns and coping strategies that create new problems requiring treatment - self-hatred/self-harm triggered by self invalidation, constant need for validation, heightened sensitivity and reaction to triggers, fear of abandonment, relationship conflicts, dissociation.